# 7

# CONSTRUCTION SKILLS

## 7.1 INTRODUCTION

We have to go through many steps in order to construct a garment. Each step has its own importance. If any step is left out, the garment can not be constructed properly. Hence it is essential for a proficient tailor to be well versed in all the various steps, which may be-seams, darts, tucks pleats, button hole, button, hook and eye, etc. But let us first learn the meaning of these terms, their types and their uses.

## 7.2 OBJECTIVES

After reading this lesson you will be able to :

- explain the various steps in garment construction;
- explain about their uses in various garments.

## 7.3 SEAMS : THEIR MEANING, NEED AND TYPES

**MEANING**

A seam is made by joining two or more pieces of fabric together.

### (a) Need for seams

1. To join the different parts of a garment.
2. To shape the garment according to the shape of the body.

3. To give strength to the joint.

4. To decorate a garment and for finishing it.

## (b) Types of seams

Seams are of the following types :-

### 1. Plain seam

The seam made by laying two pieces of fabric together and stitching 1 cm inside the edge is known as plain seam. This seam is used on most materials.

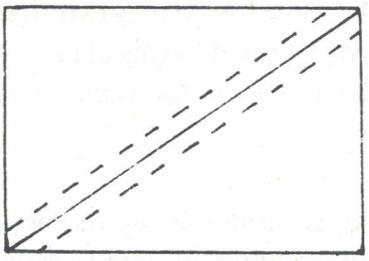


**Fig 7.1 Plain seam.**

### 2. Pinkedge seam

When the edges of the fabric are pinked after a plain seam, it is known as pinkedge seam. This seam is made on seam allowances as in a ladies kameez or side of sari blouse, etc. This is done to prevent the edge from fraying.

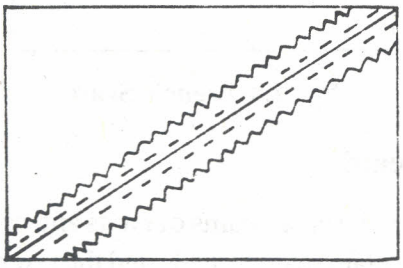


**Fig 7.2 Pink edge seam.**

### 3. Flat seam

This is also known as the 'run and fell seam'. This kind of seam is generally used in gents garments like sides of shirts, in pyjamas, etc. To make this seam, one side is cut slightly larger than the other. The first seam is given along the edge of the smaller piece. The larger side is then turned in and tacked to cover the first seam.

The second seam is then made from the right side.

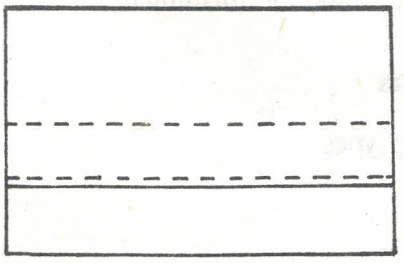
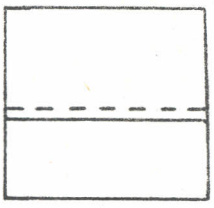


Fig 7.3 Flat seam



### 4. Top seam

The seam and on the top edge after joining two pieces of fabric together is known as a top seam. It is used to prevent fraying of raw edges of neckline, armhole and shoulders. It is commonly used in ladies and children's garments.

### 5. French seam

The first seam is made just inside the edge the fabric, on the right side. The seam is then turned over and another seam is made on the wrong side but covering the first seam. In this kind of seam, no raw edge is visible hence there is no fraying. It is generally used on synthetic fabrics and for children's garments.

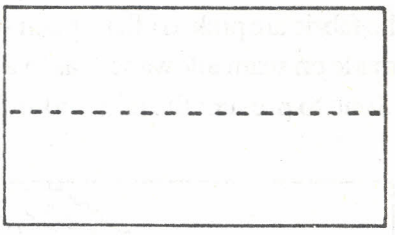


Fig 7.4 French Seam

### 6. Tacking Plain Seam

This seam is used on the back seams of pants and coats. The seam allowance is pressed open after a plain seam is made and the raw edge on both sides is turned under and secured by tacking.

### 7. Press Open Seam

When the seam allowance of a plain seam is pressed open with an iron, it is known as press open seam. It is used on some particular seams of some garments.

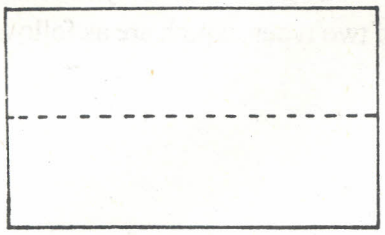


**Fig 7.5 Press Open Seam**

### 8. Self Bound Seam

As is evident from the name, this kind of seam is self bound. The edges of the seam allowance are pressed open, turned under and secured separately with a plain seam. It is generally used in gents garments like the seam on the seat of knickers or trousers.

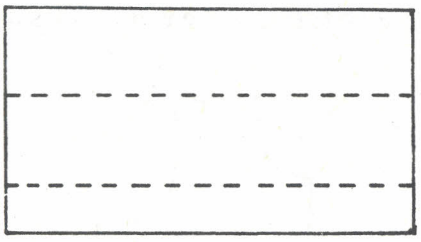


**Fig 7.6 Self Bound Seam**

## 7.4 MEANING, NEED AND TYPES OF DARTS

### a) Meaning of Darts

Darts are used to dispose of fullness in a garments or to mould the garment to the body and give a good fit. The extra cloth is taken up at the back of the garment and stitched along the line indicated in the pattern.

### b) Need for Darts

1. To give shape and fullness to a garment.
2. To make the garment well fitting.
3. To make the garment decorative and attractive.

## c) Types of Darts

Darts are used in various types of garments. They have a special importance in dress making. Darts are mainly of two types, which are as follows :-

1. Single Point Dart.
2. Double Point Dart.

### 1. Single Point Dart

This type of dart is used in blouses, frocks and at the waist of trousers. It is wide at one end and pointed at the other end. When the cloth is overlapped about 1-2 cms and stitched in a tapering manner till it reaches a single point, it is known as single point dart. These darts are generally used to dispose of fullness at particular places in garments from where they derive their names.

#### i) Waist Dart

This dart is used to give fitting at the waist and is used in blouses, frocks, etc.

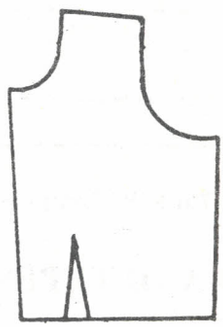


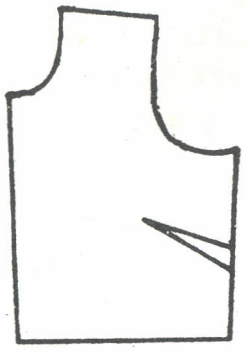
**Fig 7.7 Waist Dart**

#### ii) Side Dart

This dart is used to dispose of fullness at the bust. It is varied from wide to narrow according to the bust measurement. A wide side dart is used for a heavy bust and a narrow dart is used for a slight bust. This kind of dart is used in blouses, housecoats, etc. [Fig 7.8 (a)]

#### iii) Arm Hole Dart

This is made like the waist dart and the side dart. It starts from the curve of the arm hole and tapers inside towards the center. [Fig 7.8 (b)]



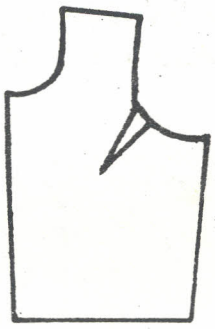
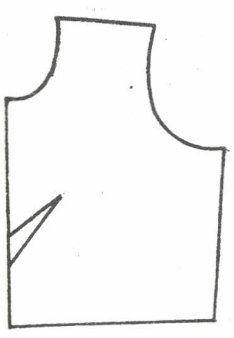


**Fig 7.8 (a) Side Dart** **(b) Arm Hole Dart**

### iv) Center Dart

This is also known as the 'bust dart'. It could be given either straight or diagonally. In ladies blouse it is given diagonally from the center front line and tapers inside towards the center.



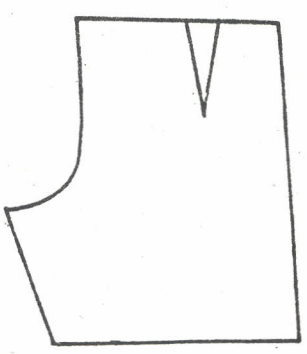


**Fig 7.9 Center Dart**

### v) Fish Dart

This dart is shaped like a fish. It starts out narrow and then widens slightly and then tapers out to a point. It is given at the waist of one piece pants and from the bottom of the armhole to the waist in a coat.

## 2. Double Point Darts

Double pointed darts have pointed ends at the top and bottom and are wide at the center. It is generally used in ladies shirt and in the back of men's shirt.

### i) French Dart

When a double point dart is made in a garment and cut from the center, it is known as a French dart.

ii) **Press Open Dart**

When the dart is pressed flat after being made, it is known as press open dart. It is generally used in garments made of heavy fabrics.

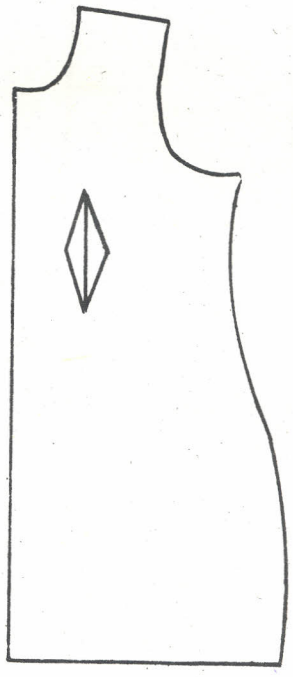


**Fig 7.10 Press open dart.**

## INTEXT QUESTIONS 7.1

Put the (√) mark on correct statement and (×) on the wrong statements.

1. Double point dart is used in ladies suit.
2. The French dart is used on heavy fabrics.
3. French seam is used on synthetic fabrics.
4. The self bound seam is like a flat seam.
5. When a seam is made on the edge of two pieces of garment it is known as top seam.

## 7.5 TUCKS - MEANING, NEED AND TYPES

### a) Meaning

When the fabric is folded from the right side and a seam is made in a particular direction and of even width, it is known as a tuck. The seam is visible on the right side of the fabric.

## b) Need

1. To give a decorative touch to a garment.
2. To hide defects in garment construction.
3. To dispose of fullness in a garment.

## c) Types of tucks

Tucks are used to make garments attractive and for creating designs. Tucks can be of the following types:-

### 1) Pin tucks

These tucks are as thin as a pin and hence are called pin tucks. These are made by machine at even widths. These are used to make garments attractive. Pin tuck can be made in any direction and get their name according to the shape in which they are made.

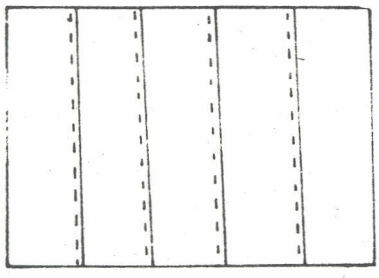


**Fig 7.11 Pin Tucks**

### 2. Square Tucks

These are made in a square shape. Longitudinal and horizontal tucks are made to intersect in order to create square tucks. These are generally used in ladies and children's garments. [Fig 7.12(a)]

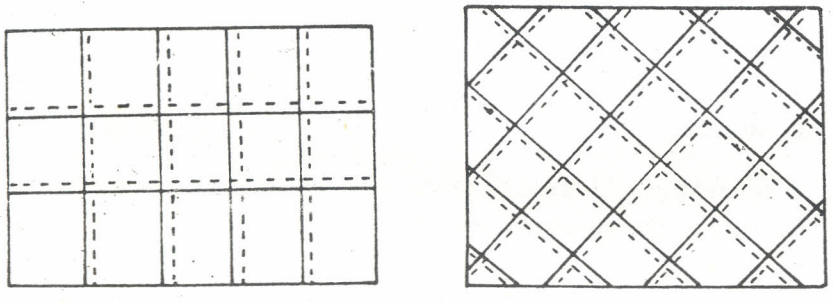


**Fig 7.12 (a) Square Tucks (b) Cross Tucks**

### 3. Cross Tucks

These are diamond shaped and are made by criss-crossing diagonal tucks. [Fig 7.12 (b)]

### 4. Corded Tucks

These are slightly thicker tucks. A cord is placed on the wrong side of the fabric and the tuck is made on the right side by holding the cord within the fold of the fabric. The corded tuck thus stands out and adds a decorative touch to the garment.

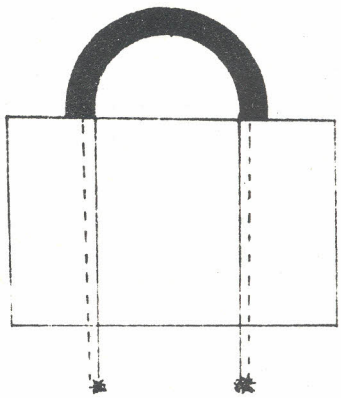


**Fig 7.13 Corded Tucks**

### 5. Shell Tucks

These tucks are very different from other tucks. The edge of the fabric is taken up about ½" to 1" and given a double stitch by hand, at regular intervals. These kinds of tucks are generally used in ladies and children garments.

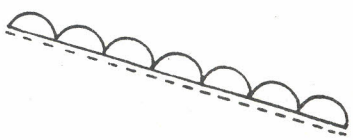


**Fig 7.14 Shell Tucks**

### 6. Graduated Tucks

When many tucks are to be given, the width of each successive tuck is gradually increased. The appearance is of graduated tucks.

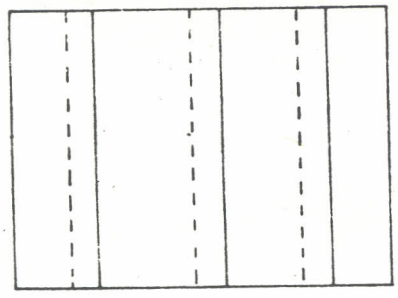


**Fig 7.15 Graduated Tucks**

## 7.6 PLEATS - MEANING, NEED & TYPES

### a) Meaning

When the extra width of material is folded over systematically to dispose of fullness in a garment it is known as a pleat.

### b) Need

1. To make a flair in a garment.
2. To dispose of fullness in a garment.
3. To give a decorative touch to a garment.

### c) Types of pleats

Pleats are used to generate designs and also to get a good fitting in a garment. Pleats can be of the following types:-

#### 1. Straight Pleats

These are simple and one-sided pleats. The extra width kept for pleats is folded over and decreased to fit the measurement. All the pleats must be facing in the same direction. One must also remember to keep the width and fold of the pleats even and equal. This kind of pleats are generally used in skirts and frocks. (Fig 7.12 (a)]

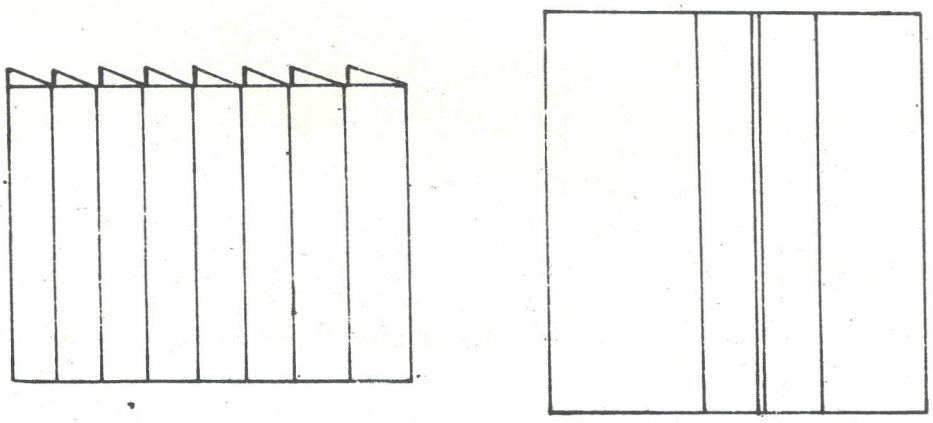


Fig 7.16 (a) Straight Pleats (b) Box Pleats.

## 2. Box Pleats

The fabric is folded on the right side and stitched length wise for about 2-4 inches from the edge. The broad pleat is then pressed flat by bringing the crease of the fold over the seam. The two equal pleats obtained on either side of the seam are known as box pleats. These are generally used in men's garments. [Fig 7.16 (b)]

## 3. Inverted Pleat

When a box pleat is made on the wrong side of the fabric it is known as inverted pleat [Fig 7.17 (a)]

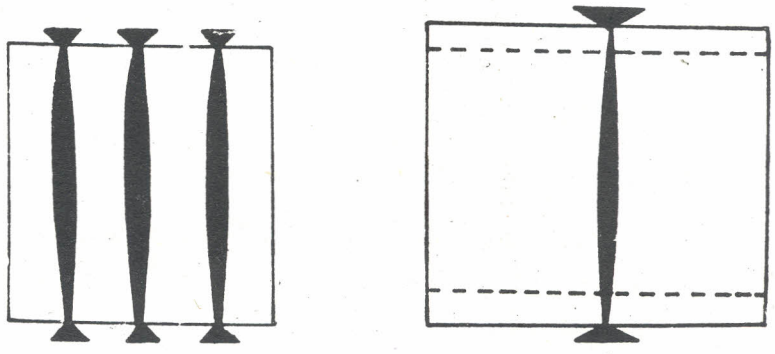


Fig 7.17 (a) Inverted Pleat (b) Meet Pleat

## 4. Meet Pleat

When the extra fabric is folded from both sides to meet in the center and is stitched at both top and bottom edges, it is known as a meet pleat. [Fig 7.17 (b)]

### 5. Knife Pleat

This is made like the inverted pleat. It is stitched on both the upper and lower edges but is left open in center. This kind of pleat is generally used in the back of a conductors uniform.

### 6. False Pleat

When a pleat is made in order to conceal defects in garment construction, it is known as a false pleat.

## INTEXT QUESTIONS 7.2

Fill in the blanks :

1. ..... pleat is formed by folding the cloth from both sides and ditching at the top and bottom.
2. ..... is made by stitching the fold of cloth at about 1" intervals.
3. Box pleats are used in ..... garments.
4. The pleat made to conceal defects is known as ..... pleat.
5. ..... pleat is made by folding the fabric from the right side at definite intervals.

**Do and see**

Try and make different types of pleats in various types of garments.

## 7.7 BUTTON HOLE

Some garments have an opening or a placket for ease of wearing or removing the garment. Button holes are made to close the placket. Button holes are mainly of two types:-

i) Worked button hole

ii) Bound button hole.

### 1. Worked button hole

This is also known as the plain button hole. It can be made both by machine and by hand. When making by machine, the button hole stitch is worked on both sides of the line marked for the button hole and the slit is made after completing the button hole. When making by hand, the button hole stitch is worked round the slit for the button hole. Worked button holes are made in various shapes, such as -

i) The fan shaped button hole is round at one end and is bound at the other. The rounded end is called the fan. An even tension must be kept while working this kind of button hole. [Fig 7.18 (i)]

ii) Some button holes are rounded at both ends. These are generally made where thick buttons are to be used. These are also made in delicate fabrics. [Fig 7.18 (ii)]

iii) Some button holes have a square end on both sides. There are generally used in men's and children's garments [Fig 7.18 (iii)]



**Fig 7.18 (i) (ii) (iii)**

iv) Tailor button hole is shaped like a flame. It has a flame shaped end and the other side is square. It is generally made 1-2 point, larger than the button. To work this kind of button hole, a thick thread is kept along the edge while the button hole stitch is being worked.

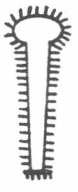


**Fig 7.19 Tailor button hole**

Button holes are made in different sizes according to the garments. They are made according to the size of buttons to be used. Button holes are generally of 5 pt. in shirts and 6 pt. in pants.

## 2. Bound button hole

To make this kind of button hole, a piece of fabric is placed over the mark for the button hole and then turned inwards to bind the edges. Hence it is called the bound button hole. It is of two types -

i) Single bound

ii) Double bound

A piece of fabric is placed over the mark for the button hole and stitched in place. The fabric is then trimmed leaving a 1 cm margin beyond the seam. The slit for the button hole is then made and the extra cloth is then neatly turned inwards and hemmed into place. It is generally used in ladies coat.

Nowadays button holes are made by machines in pant, shirt, etc. The button holes thus made are neater and it takes less time to make them. Care should be taken to see that the thread being used to make the button hole matches the fabric.

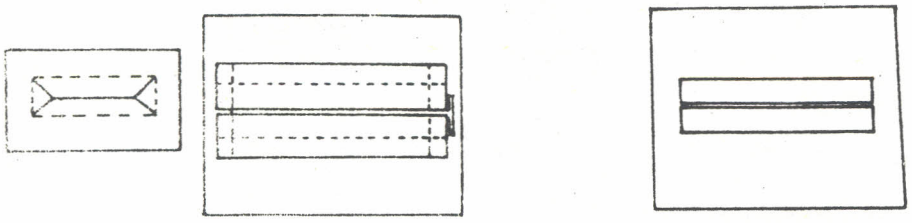


Fig 7.20

## 7.8 BUTTONS

After making the button holes, buttons are stitched for closing the placket in the garment. The size of the buttons and the button holes should be matching. Buttons can be of the following kinds :-

i) Simple/shirt button

ii) Fancy button

iii) Linen button

iv) Press button

v) Coat button

vi) Pant button

### i) Simple buttons

These are pear buttons with two or four holes. The thread used for fastening is visible over the button. These buttons get their names according to the garments they are used on such as - kurta button, pant button, shirt button, etc. After sewing on the button the thread is wound round, under the button and then fastened off on the wrong side. Buttons are available in all colors but nowadays transparent buttons are also available which can conveniently be used on garments of any colour.

### ii) Fancy buttons

These buttons are available in many sizes and shapes. They are made of plastic

(pearl), glass, shell, wood or metal. Glass buttons sometimes have designs on them. The shapes vary from round to square or triangular. Fancy buttons could be used as fasteners or simply as decorative buttons on the garment.



**Fig 7.21 (i) Simple button (ii) Fancy button**

### iii) Linen buttons

Linen buttons are made by pressing a piece of fabric between two pieces of metallic buttons. The fabric used could be the same as that of the garment or some other fabric of matching/contrasting colour. These are generally made in three sizes. These can be made at home also by wrapping the piece of fabric over a simple button and fastening off underneath and then attaching to the garment.

## 7.9 HOOK AND EYE

These are also used to close placket openings in various garments. Hooks are of two types. They are named according to the garments they are used on, like pant hook, blouse hook, press hook, etc. Hooks and eyes are of the following types.

### 1. Blouse hook

These are also known as 'small hooks' because they are small in size. These are made of steel or brass. These are used on frocks and saree blouses. The hook is always stitched on the overlapping side. The hook is paced at the marked place and stitched on three sides by using the buttonhole stitch.

The eye is made on the other side of the placket. It is usually 2 points long. It is made by taking a tacking stitch two or three times at the same place and then binding the stitch by the button hole stitch. A metallic eye may also be used and it is stitched on in the same manner as the hook.

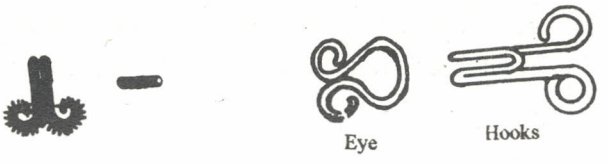



**Fig 7.22 Blouse hooks**

### 2. Pant hook

These hooks are larger in size and are used in pants, knickers, etc. These hooks are used with a metallic eye. The hook and eye are fixed at the waistband and are stitched on by using the buttonhole stitch.



**Fig 7.23 Pant hook**

### 3. Press hook

Press hooks and eyes are fixed on the garment by piercing the cloth and then pressing them in place. The advantage of using these hooks is that they take less time to fix and there is no need for needle and thread. Most tailors prefer to use these hooks now a days.

## 7.10 PRESS BUTTONS

These are commonly used fasteners. Since these are pressed closed, they are called press buttons. Press buttons have two parts - the thicker part is stitched on the lower end of the placket and the thinner one is stitched on the overlapping side of the placket. Both are stitched on with the help of the button hole stitch. Both the parts have four holes which are used for stitching them on the garment. These buttons are available in 2-3 sizes and are used in children's garments.



**Fig 7.24 i) Ring ii) Socket iii) Bottom**

## 7.11 WHAT YOU HAVE LEARNT

In this lesson you have learnt about various kinds of seams, tucks, pleats, darts, their names and their uses. You have also learnt about button holes, buttons, hook and eye and press buttons and how all these can be used for closing openings in garments and their use in giving the garment a good fitting and a decorative touch.

## 7.12 TERMINAL EXERCISE

1. Describe in detail the various kinds of seams and their uses.
2. What are button holes used for and how many types of button holes are there?
3. Distinguish between the followings:
   a) Dart and pleat
   b) Tucks and seams

## 7.13 ANSWERS TO INTEXT QUESTIONS

**7.1** i) True ii) True
iii) False iv) True

**7.2** i) Neat pleat ii) Shell tucks
iii) Scout shirt, skirt iv) False pleat
v) Tucks